Which tag should a Thai 2D indie studio pair with its next Steam game?

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1 The decision

Which second tag the studio builds and markets its next 2D game around. Owner: game director, before the concept brief. If a partner passed the rule, the brief commits to it; as none did, two are tested first.

2 Why a network

A tag count cannot say which tags travel with 2D, which pairings are crowded, or which partner bridges into other genre neighbourhoods and so reaches a second audience.

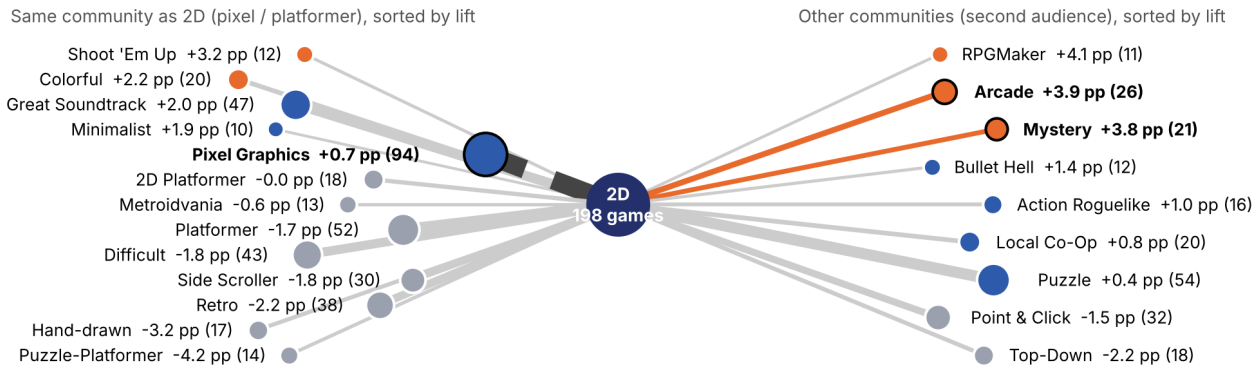
3 Data

Source	SteamSpy public API (tag, appdetails); Steam store pages and appreviews as checks
Method	Python, 1.1 s delay; random 600 (seed 7202) of 6,287 Indie games with ≥500 reviews; 15 Oct 2026
Legal	Public APIs, no key; robots.txt allows SteamSpy and store /app/; aggregates only, no user data; raw pulls not shared
Volume	592 games kept (≥5 tags); median 1,585 reviews, 85.9% positive
Bias	Survivors only: failed games invisible; player-voted tags, so synonyms co-exist
Check	29 random games vs Steam store: 84% of top-15 and 83% of top-5 tags match; reviews ρ 0.99 (30 games)

4 Graph construction

Node / edge	Tag; edge = both in a game's top-15 voted tags
Weight	NPMI, not raw count: raw ranks 2D–Pixel Graphics first (94); NPMI ranks synonyms first (Rogue-like–lite 0.84)
Window, metrics	Top-15 tags (10, 20 swept); betweenness (distance 1/NPMI), participation coefficient
Pruning	Seed Indie out (77% of games); generic ≥40% out (Singleplayer, Adventure, Action); ≥10 games; NPMI ≥0.10
Size	157 nodes, 2,342 edges (of 6,830 pairs); figure: 2D's 22 partners
Rule	Fixed in the notebook before the pull, unchanged: ≥10 shared games, top lift, #1 in ≥60% of 500 bootstraps

5 The picture



2D's ego network. Closer = higher NPMI; width = shared games; label = review lift vs 2D-only (n). Dashed = most crowded; orange = test arms.

6 Findings

- **The obvious partner is crowded and adds nothing.** Pixel Graphics is on 94 of 198 2D games (47%), 2D's strongest tie (NPMI 0.43), yet lifts positive reviews only +0.7 pp (p 0.57); 8 of 13 same-community partners score below 2D-only games.
- **The upside is outside 2D's community; Arcade bridges, Mystery does not.** Arcade +3.9 pp (26 games, p 0.11) is one of 3 partners in the top 7 of 22 on both participation (#3) and betweenness (#7); Mystery +3.8 pp (21, p 0.11) is last on participation (#22). RPGMaker (+4.1 pp, 11) is an engine tag, not a positioning choice: not tested.
- **No partner passes the pre-set rule.** RPGMaker leads only 2 of 9 window × cutoff specs; the bootstrap leader (Arcade) holds #1 in 13% of 500 resamples. Pairs of 21–26 games lack power to confirm a 4 pp gap.

7 Recommended action

- **By 23 Oct:** game director drops Pixel Graphics as the positioning claim (art style only) and writes two concepts: 2D + Arcade (bridge) and 2D + Mystery (one new neighbourhood).
- **30 Oct–13 Nov:** both as ad variants to one Steam 'coming soon' page, 2D + Pixel Graphics as control; keep a variant only with ≥20% more wishlists per 1,000 impressions.
- **By 20 Nov:** re-run on all 6,287 games (≈10× the games) with synonym tags merged and the same rule; commit to a partner only if it passes 60%.

8 What would change my mind

Pairs that review well do not cause good reviews, and only survivors are visible. If the full-pool re-run puts another partner above 60%, or neither variant beats control, I would brief a plain 2D game.